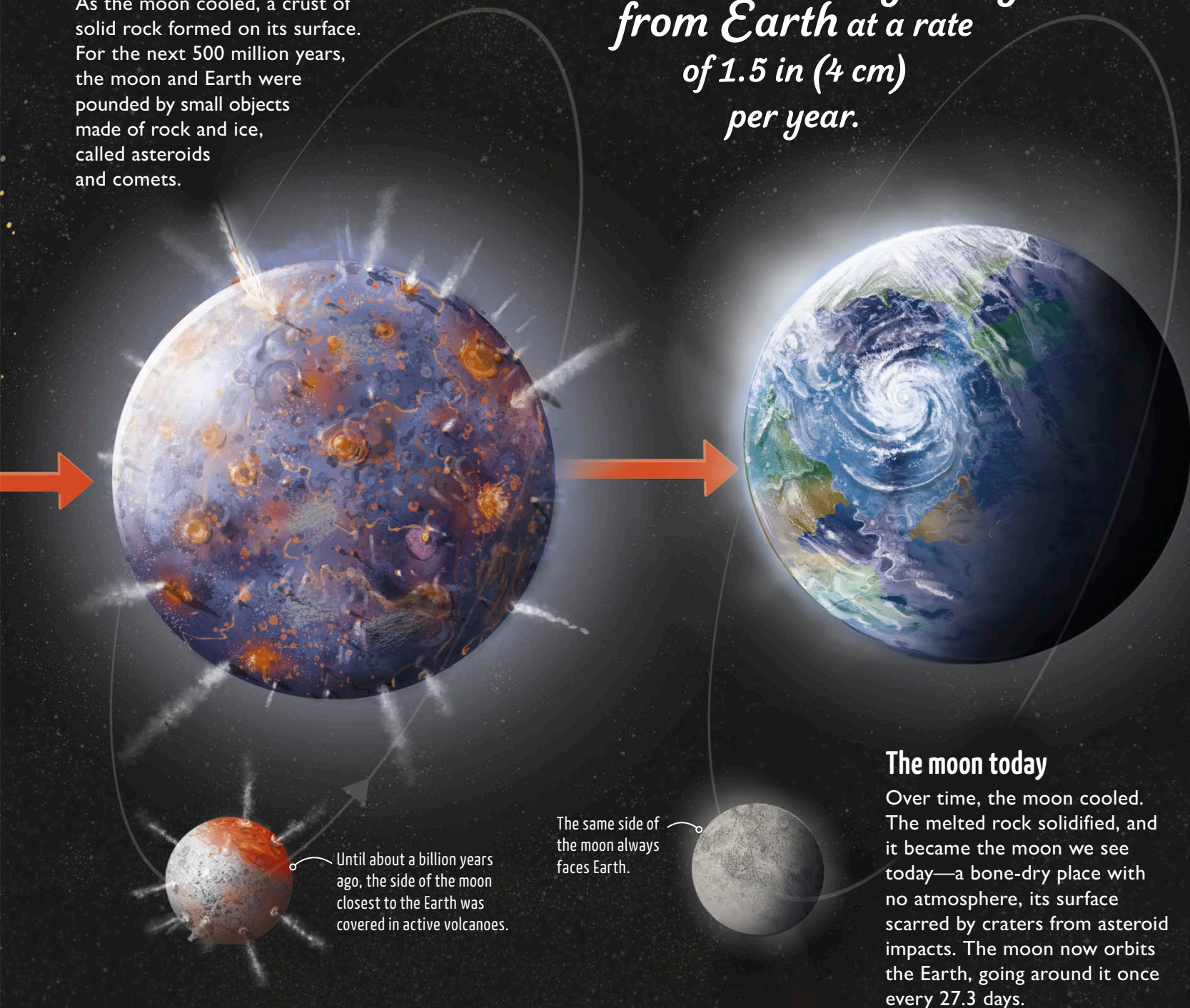


Asteroids and comets

As the moon cooled, a crust of solid rock formed on its surface. For the next 500 million years, the moon and Earth were pounded by small objects made of rock and ice, called asteroids and comets.

The moon is moving away from Earth at a rate of 1.5 in (4 cm) per year.



The moon today

Over time, the moon cooled. The melted rock solidified, and it became the moon we see today—a bone-dry place with no atmosphere, its surface scarred by craters from asteroid impacts. The moon now orbits the Earth, going around it once every 27.3 days.

Tides The moon affects the ocean tides. Gravity pulls at the water on Earth, causing it to bulge out. As the moon orbits the Earth, it pulls this water bulge with it, which makes sea levels rise and fall. These movements are the tides.

